respect their judgement. They rarely have a say in determining what ‘benefit’ they want. They are passive recipients only.

A few schemes have been started by the Central government to deliver direct benefit or cash to the ‘beneficiary’. Multiple ministries and departments implement such direct benefit schemes. The government still does not focus on individual households and deliver a package of direct benefits suiting their needs and aspirations.

This redistribution mechanism needs to be transformed.

For this, as proposed above, we must identify and categorize the economically poor households of India into three groups: poorest of the poor/destitute (who cannot earn a living), economically poor (with deficiency between their objectively determined standard needs and the income they earn) and economically vulnerable (who are economically fine normally but tend to fall back in poverty during times of emergency).

The redistribution package for each of these three groups should be restructured.

The destitute can be provided only cash income support, directly delivered.

The poor can be served by providing mostly cash support along with a few products in kind (largely delivered through vouchers).

Contingency support programmes for the vulnerable should kick in only during emergencies and disasters.

It is not very difficult to identify about 20 crore of destitute, poor and vulnerable households of India. The Economic and Caste Census did a lot of groundwork for this. A slightly refined methodology can deliver these lists. It will save much of the waste, delay and leakage that the present system entails.